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The Calculus of Retention



Why Are Yale Students Leaving STEM?

Featuring A Light in the Shul: New Haven's Jewish Population Finds Community After Tragedy

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A Light in the Shul



New Haven's Jewish Population Finds Community After Tragedy

BY **KALEY PILLINGER** AND **MOLLY SHAPIRO**

PHOTOS BY **DANIEL ZHAO**

RABBI MENDY HECHT'S VOICE echoes as he gestures toward the synagogue window. "All the parking lots that you see? That was all Jewish and Italian communities."

Orchard Street Shul, a 1920s brick synagogue on a quiet residential block close to downtown New Haven, was built to echo, so that congregants could hear the cantor from any one of the synagogue's 600 seats.

Today, those pews are never full.

When Hecht's grandfather was the spiritual leader of Orchard Street Shul in the 1940s, the synagogue was a fixture of the New Haven Jewish community. In those days, children could run from services on Saturday night over to Legion Avenue for their pick of Jewish bakeries and shops.

Most New Haven Jews will tell you, with an air of resignation, that the city's Jewish population is waning—aging, leaving, disappearing. But Rabbi Hecht refuses to believe it. Though he admits that Jewish engagement looks different today, he maintains that the community is still strong. "It's not because I'm an eternal optimist," he said. "It's because I *want* to be optimistic."

"IS THIS RIGHT?" our taxi driver asks.

In the darkness, it is hard to tell. The only sign of life outside Congregation Beth El-Keser Israel (BEKI), a building that looks more like a school than a synagogue, is a man standing in front of the door. He greets the congregants who enter, but he does not know their names.

The lobby is hardly more lively. Four middle-aged men sit on couches as they await the start of Shabbat services. One of them is the rabbi, Jon-Jay Tilsen. He explains that the man at the door is his Christian neighbor, here this Friday night in solidarity. It is the first Shabbat after 11 Jews were killed at the Tree of Life Synagogue in Pittsburgh on October 27.

At 6 p.m., the congregants migrate from the lobby to the room where services are held. There are no stained glass windows or pews, but the wooden ark where the Torah sits indicates that this is a holy space. Bookshelves line the cinder block walls, and wall-to-wall carpeting warms the room.

Most seats are empty when the services start, but slowly, families trickle in. The cantor, who faces away from his audience as he leads them in prayer, seems to expect the latecomers.

The only mention of the recent tragedy comes at the end of the service, when Rabbi Tilsen leads congregants in the Kaddish—the prayer for mourning—and reads the names of the 11 dead. Even this minor acknowledgement of the shooting makes Rabbi Tilsen hesitate. He understands Shabbat as a respite from the issues of the day.

Rabbi Tilsen believes in commemoration through action, not discussion. "I'm beyond vigils," he said. "A vigil has value in the moment, but there are other things I want to do." Still, the previous Sunday, he attended the Jewish Federation Vigil at the Jewish Community Center (JCC), along with nearly 1,000 other Jews from the Greater New Haven area. "I'm glad I went," he reflected. "I felt like I was doing my job."

The Friday services close with blessings over wine, and Rabbi Tilsen bids everyone "Shabbat Shalom," a routine wish for peace that meant so much less the week before.

Congregation members, most of whom live in nearby Westville, exchange goodbyes and walk home to begin the Sabbath.

DURING THE WEEK, a lone Kosher grocery—one of a handful within driving distance of downtown New Haven—is a rare sign that Westville is a Jewish neighborhood. But on Saturday mornings, the community comes to life as families walk to BEKI for Shabbat services.

Today, Westville is known as one of the centers of Jewish life in New Haven. But this was not always the case.

In the first half of the 20th century, most of New Haven's Jews lived in the Legion Avenue and Wooster Square areas. Back then, the Jewish communities were easier to spot. When Rabbi Hecht talks to long-time congregants about that era, they tell stories of "running up and down with a nickel getting their fountain soda and the warm bakery products—the rugelach and the challahs," he said. "They all talk about Saturday night like it was Times Square."

Paul Bass, editor of the *New Haven Independent* and a BEKI congregant, explained that the Jewish community started moving in 1955. That year, New Haven Mayor Richard C. Lee introduced a plan to construct a highway that would cut through the Legion Avenue area, which was considered then to be the "Jewish Ghetto."

Jews were forced to leave the area for the construction project, which was never even realized. Although Jews were already relocating at the time, their departure was "hastened by the tearing of land that was never built," Bass said.

The following decades saw a Jewish exodus from the city center, caused by the push of eminent domain and the pull of suburban life, which residents could now afford. The synagogues moved with them.

"That was urban renewal," Bass said. "That's the story of America."

BEKI is the amalgam of two synagogues displaced by the never-built highway. Beth El and Keser Israel combined in 1968.

With an initial membership of over 600 families, the newly-formed BEKI started strong. But by the late 1970s, its congregants had aged, its facilities had begun to crumble, and the threat of closure loomed. When Rabbi Tilsen arrived in New Haven from Norwich, Connecticut in 1993, BEKI "was questioning its reason to exist or how it was going to exist," he said. Some felt BEKI should pursue another merger.

"There are a lot of Jews, but they're not necessarily poking their heads out of the sand."

An influx of young families in the mid-1990s saved the synagogue. By today's standards, Bass said, "BEKI is thriving." Still, the congregation currently numbers 300 families—half its size in the 1960s.

THE TURNOUT AT THE JEWISH Federation Vigil impressed Rabbi Hecht. "It's the most I've ever seen in that building," he said.

In its most recent report in 2011, the Jewish Federation of New Haven predicted that the number of Jews in the Greater New Haven area—which has the second largest Jewish community in Connecticut—would continue to decrease.

A small population isn't necessarily a problem, though. Rabbi Fred Hyman, who previously worked in Park East Synagogue in New York City, likes the community's size. In New Haven, he said, "every individual is important."

Because two-thirds of New Haven's Jewish population comes from elsewhere, many of the city's Jews do not have extended family nearby. The synagogue, Rabbi Tilsen said, "plays the role that a family or extended family might play, whether it's looking after your kids when you're going out, or sharing holidays."

As Bass put it, being Jewish in New Haven is "kind of ideal—you get to have a strong sense of community and identity, but you also get the diversity of the city."

Rabbi Hecht is skeptical that the numbers are shrinking. Instead, he thinks that younger generations just aren't publicly identifying as Jewish.

"Forty years ago, people at age 25 said 'Oh, where's the JCC? Where's the synagogue I want to belong to?' and they joined. That's not happening today," he said. "There are a lot of Jews, but they're not necessarily poking their heads out of the sand."

He describes the engagement of younger generations as "a la carte"—twenty-somethings who have just moved to the city for graduate school, Rabbi Hecht said, want to have a meaningful spiritual experience and a place for weddings, bar mitzvahs, and funerals without committing to weekly services.

Orchard Street Shul has done its best to adapt to the changing needs of Jews in New Haven. The synagogue hosts events like Sushi and Shots and Shabbat Socials, which consist of services and happy hours.

Rabbi Hecht understands his job to be, in large part, about outreach. In his view, the Jewish community cannot thrive if synagogues resign themselves to a "let-me-put-my-shingle-up-and-wait-for-the-people-to-come" mentality. Without constant engagement and adaptation, he said, "You're just going to wake up one day and be like, 'Whoa, we went from 500 members to 200 members. What happened?'"

"THE UNTHINKABLE HAPPENED in Pittsburgh on October 27th," said Judy Alperin, the chief executive officer of the Jewish Federation of Greater New Haven. "By the next evening, we were able to convene the community for an interfaith vigil."



The Federation is a nonprofit charged with caring for and connecting Jews who live in the Greater New Haven area. "When something horrible like this shooting happens, we are the main conveners who bring the community together," Alperin explained.

Shelly Kagan, Clark Professor of Philosophy at Yale, attended the vigil and recalled not being able to find a parking spot or a seat. "The auditorium was full and crowds were spilling out the doorways," he said.

For Kagan, the shooting was personal. He had worked as an assistant professor in Pittsburgh for five years and was a member of Dor Hadash, one of the congregations that meets in the building where the shooting occurred.

"I had the very striking realization that if I had stayed in Pittsburgh, I could well have been in the building at the time," Kagan reflected. "I think any Jew in America finds this a difficult experience." But for him and his wife, Kagan said, "The associations run deeper."

They attended the vigil because they "were looking to be with others," Kagan said. Many felt the same way. "I think when people feel vulnerable they come together to feel safe," Rabbi Hecht observed.

The religious leaders who spoke at the vigil emphasized the importance of unity. Rabbi Benjamin Scolnic of Temple Beth Shalom told the audience, "We have to understand that if someone is a hater, it doesn't make any difference if they happen to hate this ethnic group or that nationality. … If anyone hates any group, they hate us."

In the spirit of Scolnic's remarks, the speaker lineup featured non-Jewish leaders such as Reverend Steven Cousin of Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church and Fatma Antar of the Muslim Coalition of Connecticut.



"We made a conscious choice to make it an interfaith vigil," Alperin said. "There is tremendous strength that comes when people of all good conscience come together."

Reverend Cousin spoke about the persecution of black and Jewish Americans. He said that the Jewish

"There is tremendous strength that comes when people of all good conscience come together."

"We have to be proud to act Jewishly. When you cower in fear, that's the dangerous part."

community provided support after the 2015 church shooting in Charleston, South Carolina and that now it was the black community's turn to do the same. "I would like to tell those of the Jewish community that we are standing with you," he said. "We love you. We are mourning with you. And we are grieving with you."

Rabbi Hecht appreciated the strength and solidarity that the vigil represented.

"When people attack us with actions, we have to respond with actions. We have to be proud to act Jewishly," he said. "When you cower in fear, that's the dangerous part."

ALPERIN MADE SURE to have the Woodbridge Police Department on site during the vigil.

"The fact that it happened in a shul obviously brought it closer to home," Rabbi Hecht said of the Pittsburgh shooting. "It made everyone feel vulnerable. This could happen anywhere, at any time, in any synagogue."

Since Pittsburgh, synagogues all over the Greater New Haven area have begun to scrutinize their security practices. Safety has always been a concern, but Rabbi Hyman, who leads Westville Shul, said that it is now discussed with heightened urgency.

At BEKI, congregants are considering enhancing the network of security cameras in the building, increasing the number of paid security guards, and adding emergency call buttons.

Harold Birn, BEKI's president, explained the synagogue's rationale: "The reason we added the armed security was even less to do with actual security and a little more to do with the feeling of security."

For some congregants, the idea of needing security is new. Rabbi Tilsen said his children see anti-Semitism as "something strange and unusual" and have always felt safe in services.

Kagan, however, has long understood synagogues as likely targets. "I grew up in the shadow of the Holocaust. It's not news to me that people are always trying to kill the Jews," he said. "For me, it's always been the thought that people hate Jews every place and you're never completely safe."

Synagogues moved quickly in response to congregants' fears. But according to Rabbi Hecht, the City of New Haven did not react with the same speed. He said that when he asked for a New Haven Police Department squad car to sit outside of Shabbat services at Orchard Street Shul, the department balked.

"They told me New Haven's understaffed," Rabbi Hecht said with a frustrated laugh. "I said, 'Listen buddy, you're gonna find a car for us, because it might not be me, but someone's going to raise hell if there isn't a car there on Friday night.' Thank God they came through."

Still, for all the comfort that security provides, it comes with complications.

"Two days ago, I was a few minutes late to services and the door was locked," Kagan said. "I remembered they had just sent an email saying they're not comfortable keeping the door open when there's not somebody there."

This is precisely what Rabbi Hyman fears. "We want to have a place that's open," Rabbi Hyman said. He worries that security measures may make it harder for members—especially those coming to services for the first time—to enter the building and join the community. If people are deterred from joining a synagogue, "that would be a shame," he said, "but we just have to do our best."

THE PEWS AT WESTVILLE SHUL were more crowded the weekend after Pittsburgh. Rabbi Hyman knew this would happen. He was more concerned with turnout at the next weekend's Shabbat.

Unlike many other rabbis, Rabbi Hyman didn't send an email imploring people to show up for the Shabbat after the shooting. He saved his email for the following week. "That's really where the effort can be—

"It's not news to me that people are always trying to kill the Jews."



"One of the most beautiful concepts about light is that it doesn't have to fight with darkness."

strengthening one another over time, not just one Shabbat after," he said.

Rabbi Hyman hopes to sustain the increased attendance that followed Pittsburgh: "I think that's part of what I want to emphasize going forward: defining a renewed sense of peace in shul and spiritual connection."

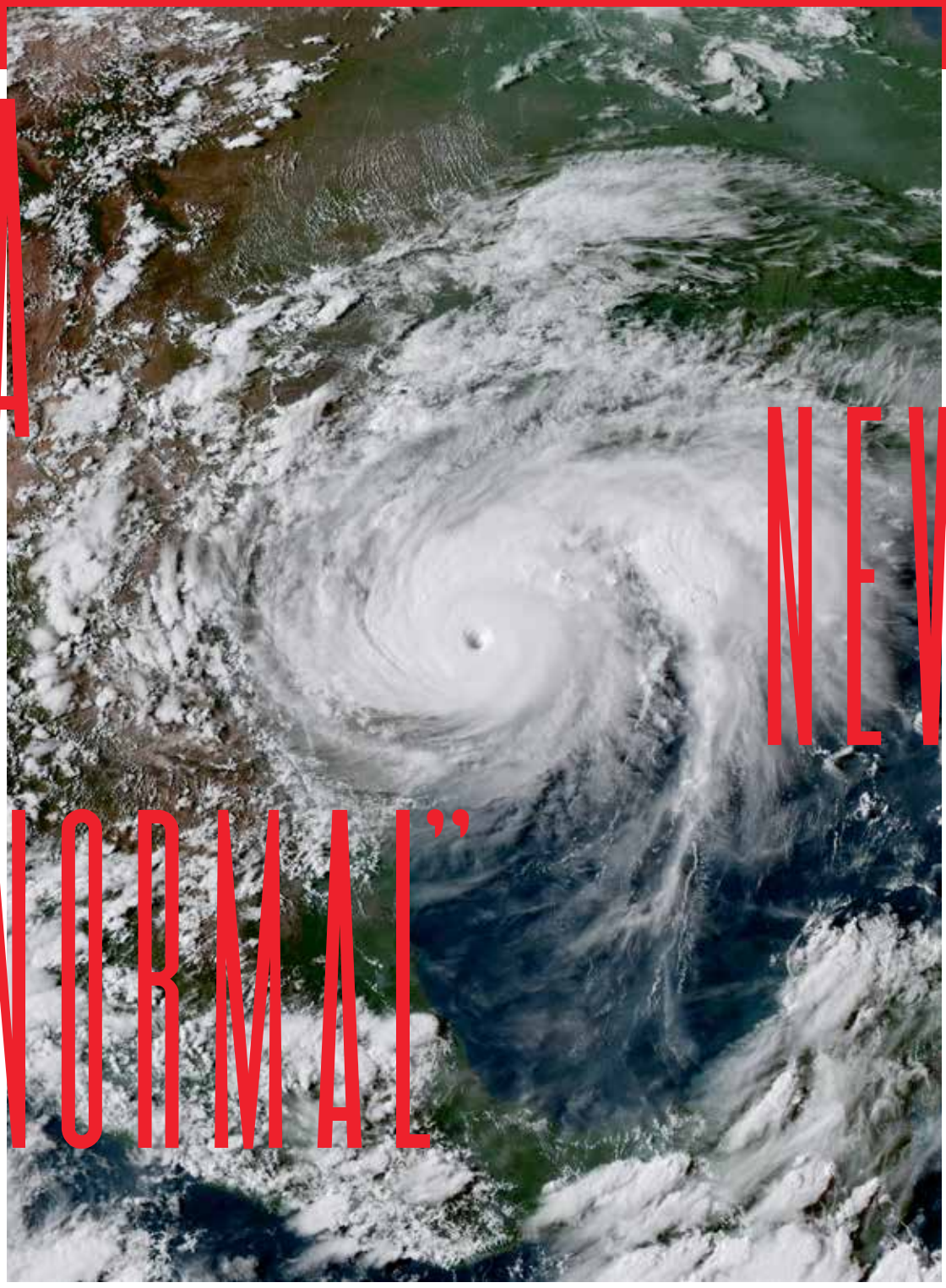
As New Haven's Jewish community continues to move out of the city and shift away from synagogue life, the tragedy of Pittsburgh has spurred a kind of spiritual awakening. In the wake of the shooting, local synagogue leaders are striving to preserve the newfound engagement.

Rabbi Hyman hopes that the glimmer sparked by Pittsburgh will not fade. "It doesn't have to go back to normal," he said. "We can still try to change ourselves a little bit."

Ever the optimist, Rabbi Hecht sees the community's response to Pittsburgh as a bright spot during dark times.

"One of the most beautiful concepts about light is that it doesn't have to fight with darkness. You turn on a light, and all of a sudden it automatically transforms the space," he said. "We can't counteract every act of crisis, but we can do our part in trying to make the world a better, more positive place."

"A NEW NORMAL"



Frequent Hurricanes, Forgotten First Responders

BY **CHRISTINA TUTTLE**

WHEN GILLIAN COX, a volunteer firefighter and mother in her thirties, drove into Rockport, Texas, she could barely recognize her hometown. The night prior, on August 25, 2017, Hurricane Harvey had barreled through the small town, flattening buildings with 100 mile-per-hour winds and relentless downpours. "It looked like we'd been wiped off the face of the Earth," Cox recalled.

Cox is no stranger to emergency response. At 14 years old, she formed a junior fire department in her town of Walpole, New Hampshire. Now, Cox is a fifth-generation firefighter and serves as a captain of the Rockport Volunteer Fire Department.

Arriving in Rockport after Harvey felt like "driving into a movie," Cox said. Seeing the damaged homes, skeletal trees, and scattered debris was "emotional" and "completely surreal." But Cox did not have time to dwell on her emotions. It was time to get to work.

After natural disasters, first responders—firefighters, law enforcement officers, emergency medics, and outside volunteer groups—are tasked with confronting destruction and providing the initial wave of aid to a devastated area. Hurricanes pose a unique set of challenges. They occur infrequently and with little advance warning, leaving first responders short of funds and resources.

Once a storm passes, first-response departments often lack the means to rebuild infrastructure and support the psychological recovery of their own personnel. Communities are left vulnerable to future natural disasters. As climate change intensifies and hurricanes become more severe, the shortage of crucial resources for first responders shows no sign of letting up.

"The devastation from major disasters like Category 4 or 5 hurricanes isn't going to go away overnight. You don't see normalcy for many years," Florida firefighter and first responder Alexander Baird said. "We're still living the disaster here."

WHEN HURRICANE MICHAEL slammed into Mexico Beach, Florida, devastating the oceanfront city last October, Ronnie Stevens was hundreds of miles away, in Houston, Texas. Within hours of learning of the destruction, Stevens loaded his truck with supplies—generators, tarps, food, water, chainsaws, and fuel—and drove to Florida as a volunteer first responder.

A year earlier, when Hurricane Harvey hit Texas, Stevens, the center chief of security at NASA's Johnson Space Center, served on the response team that helped the Space Center recover. With a truckload of supplies and his experience in disaster management, Stevens felt obligated to offer his assistance to Mexico Beach.

Upon arriving, Stevens distributed most of his supplies to first-response staging areas, which are sites for coordinating resource distribution and other response efforts. Over the next week, Stevens worked with a volunteer response team, using his chainsaws to clear pathways to homes for handicapped residents. Stevens believes that local volunteers are essential to first response.

"You need to have locals that can come in and provide that initial support that the state can't because they're so busy. You see local volunteers filling that gap, providing direct assistance to citizens," Stevens said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Volunteers become especially crucial when the state lacks sufficient personnel to respond to a disaster. During Harvey, firefighters with the Houston Fire Department stayed awake for several consecutive days responding to emergencies. Eventually, when the firefighters became too fatigued to move, some units were forced to go out of service. Emergency calls were still waiting.

"It was a disaster within a disaster," Stephen Jasinski, a captain of the Houston Fire Department, told *The Politic*.

IN TEXAS, THE PROBLEM was not just a lack of resources but a lack of the right resources. After Harvey, outside donations began pouring into Rockport. But according to Cox, this support was sometimes as ineffective as it was overwhelming.

While some people did directly contact the Rockport Fire Department to ask

< Hurricane Harvey devastated Rockport, Texas in August 2017. Photo via **NOAA/Wikimedia Commons**

how they could best contribute, other well-meaning individuals arrived unannounced with trailers full of donated blankets and clothes—resources that Rockport did not need. With buildings destroyed by the hurricane, there was nowhere to store the donations, and they were often unloaded into open lots.

"That was really disheartening. You know that someone worked really hard to collect and gather all that stuff, and it would just get dumped in a parking lot," Cox said. "Sometimes it was used, but a lot of times it would end up in the trash."

In Florida, Stevens witnessed similar problems with resource distribution. Driving around the Mexico Beach area, he saw distribution centers overflowing with unused supplies while towns remained in "desperate need." Stevens said this failure to coordinate supplies was the result of poor communication by the county government. To improve supply distribution, he suggested using a focused social media site to inform the public about resource needs in specific areas.

Cox proposed a simple rule for prospective donors: "Give cash, not trash."

WHEN ALEXANDER BAIRD stepped outside Florida's Panama City Fire Station, where he and other firefighters had sought shelter during Hurricane Michael, the first things he noticed were the trees. Looking around, huge oak and pine trees were everywhere, uprooted, blocking streets or crushing houses. More debris—power lines, chunks of roof, and other items—covered the ground.

This was not Baird's first time responding to a hurricane. Almost three decades earlier, in 1992, Baird helped to relieve firefighters in Homestead, Florida, in the aftermath of Hurricane Andrew. Since then, he has responded to multiple other hurricanes.

A music major in college, Baird said he "fell into" his job in firefighting after serving in the Air Force. After 35 years in the fire service, he is now Panama City's fire chief.

Baird felt prepared to respond to Hurricane Michael. And he was familiar with the psychological toll that storms can take on first responders.

"For these firefighters in the streets trying to save others, at the same time their homes have been devastated and they have to deal with their own problems," Baird told *The Politic*. "These guys amaze the hell out of me with what they do for the community and the sacrifices they make."

First responders must also endure the extreme demands of their work schedules. For the first two weeks after Michael, Baird slept on the floor of his office every day, going to sleep at 11 p.m. and waking up at 3 a.m. the next morning.

The combination of emotional trauma and physical exertion may have serious mental health consequences. According to a report by the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, first responders face a heightened risk of depression, substance abuse, post traumatic stress disorder, and suicide.

Glen Rogers, the fire chief in Wrightsville Beach, North Carolina, has begun to see a psychological toll among his firefighters in the aftermath of Hurricane Florence, which hit Wrightsville Beach in mid-September. In his department, Rogers told *The Politic*, he observed the worst trauma in the months following the hurricane, after the initial adrenaline rush had subsided. Some of Rogers' firefighters struggle to grapple with the destruction of their own homes, while others

"Even after it cleaned up, it's still there in your mind, and you have to deal mentally with that."

experience survivor's guilt.

Some departments bring in mental health professionals to run critical incident stress briefings, where firefighters can discuss their experiences of a disaster. But others, like Rogers' department in Wrightsville Beach, offer no such resources.

To Baird, psychological effects are some of the most enduring impacts of the hurricane. "Every day you come to work, it can be depressing to drive down the street and see the debris and devastation still here," he said. "Even after it's cleaned up, it's still there in your mind, and you have to deal mentally with that."

AFTER RESPONDING TO THE community's needs, the Rockport Volunteer Fire Department turned to its own station. During Harvey, the station lost its communication tower, which will cost 300,000 dollars to replace.

To fund this crucial equipment, the department applied for multiple grants, including ones from the Rebuild Texas Fund and the Federal Emergency Management Agency. All of the applications were denied. Cox currently spends 15 to 20 hours per week writing grants and researching funding opportunities. The department also used some of its limited resources to hire grant writers. Still, the firefighters have yet to find funding, and the tower has yet to be built.

Cox is exasperated. "I feel like it's all a game: whoever can do the paperwork the best gets the money. That's not what we're good at. We're not good at paperwork. We are a volunteer fire department, and we're good at what we do," she said. "We were here doing our job during the hurricane, and now we're not getting any help from the federal government. That is really frustrating to me."

COX BELIEVES PART of the problem is her unit's status as a volunteer fire department.

"Fire departments are grossly overlooked and neglected. The federal government looks at the department and says, 'Well, we don't give them anything and they still get the job done,' which is true—we will figure out a way to save people's lives," Cox said. "But, the federal government can certainly make it easier for us by helping us with these grants."

Cox also reported decreases in other income. Last year, she said, donations dropped by 60 percent.

Volunteer fire departments are not the only first responders struggling financially. According to Baird, the professional Panama City Fire Department relies on revenue from property taxes, sales taxes, and hotel taxes—all sectors which were severely impacted by Hurricane Michael.

"Moving forward, how are we going to budget when we don't have the revenue in the city?" Baird asked.

Baird, Cox, Stevens, and Jasinski expressed a need for increased hurricane preparation resources, from personnel response training to all-terrain vehicles for rescuing victims in devastated areas.

Jasinski believes that insufficient hurricane preparation and response funding is a product of "complacency from the infrequency" of these disasters.

"These are things that get cut very quickly because they are low frequency events," Jasinski said. "Unfortunately, the low frequency events are the ones that often cost us the most in human lives."

SOME CLIMATE SCIENTISTS say the severity of recent hurricanes like Michael and Harvey may be a preview of what's to come. According to the Center for Climate and Energy Solutions, climate change is expected to intensify the impacts of hurricanes, and climate models predict a significant increase in the frequency of Category 4 and 5 storms.

"Since I've been here in North Carolina, we've had two 500-year storms," Rogers said, referring to hurricanes so severe that they would not be expected to occur more than twice in a millenium. "Is this a new normal?"

"This is what first responders do," Baird said. "They sacrifice their own lives, their own needs, for the needs of the community—and they do it willingly."

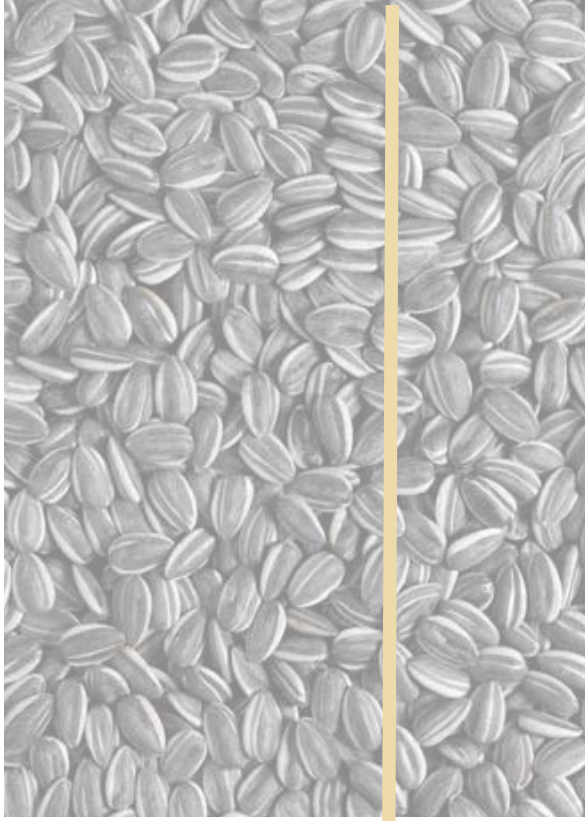
Portrait



the Artist as
of Counterculture

Reconciling Art with Politics in China

BY **ANDREW BELLAH**



IN FEBRUARY 1989, a young woman strode through an exhibition in the Chinese National Gallery of Art. She passed installations by over a dozen artists—Wang Guangyi, Zhang Xiaogang, and Ye Yongqing among them—and an array of paintings, prints, and sculptures that experimented with form and content. She approached an installation toward the back of the exhibition, pulled a handgun from her jacket, and fired two shots into the sculpture.

Chaos erupted as mirrored glass shattered. People ran for the exits, and security guards ran for the woman. Xiao Lu surrendered her weapon on site.

Xiao was an artist, and the piece she'd chosen to assassinate was her own, titled *Dialogue*. The installation consisted of two glass telephone booths. A man and a woman were shown speaking on the phone, presumably to one another, in separate booths. Above them Xiao had written Chinese words relating to communication. Between the two booths, a red dial-up phone was perched on a pedestal, its receiver unhooked as if someone had dropped it in the middle of a conversation. Xiao had assembled the piece with a fellow artist, Tang Song. On the first day of the exhibition, without clear or apparent reason, Xiao decided to kill it.

She left her actions open to interpretation. Media outlets from around the world tried to contact Xiao, Tang, and other artists associated with the exhibition. The story in most newsfeeds was that Xiao had committed a brazen, highly symbolic act meant to

protest the Chinese government's tight regulation of what works were allowed to be shown in the exhibition. Some artists and counterculturalists in China celebrated Xiao for taking a shot at the authority of the Chinese government.

The government responded with immediate and harsh suppression. It closed down the exhibition and refused to show any more contemporary art there. Demonstrators gathered outside the gallery, part of a larger movement against suppression of creative expression that shook China that spring. In June of the same year, the government famously cracked down on protests in Tiananmen Square, during a day of violence known in China as the June Fourth Incident.

Chinese artists have long imbued their work with political and social commentary. During the Communist Revolution, when most publicly displayed art existed to promote the socialist state, Chairman Mao Zedong said, "There is in fact no such thing as art for art's sake, art that stands above classes, art that is independent of politics. … Artworks are, as Lenin said, cogs and wheels in the revolutionary machine."

As China transformed into a Communist state, virtually all public art took the form of pro-state propaganda. *Xuānchuán*, meaning "dissemination" or "thought exchange," was propaganda intended to create a cult of personality around Mao and the Communist Party. The use of art as propaganda skyrocketed during the Cultural Revolution.

"In the time of suppr
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A transition to laxer censorship policies—ushered in unexpectedly by Mao's death in 1976, the Sino-Soviet split, and the ascension of Deng Xiaoping as prime minister—accompanied a moderate liberalization of China's economy. Artists like Wang Guangyi experimented with ideas of capitalism and consumerism. Simultaneously, other artists, like Ai Weiwei and the Stars Art Group, actively protested the government.

This period of emerging political and social commentary in art lasted until 1989, when the government began suppressing free expression again after the violence in Tiananmen Square. Many artists, like Ai, went underground and worked from undisclosed locations. Below the surface, underground art remained highly political, but in public, many artists moved away from overtly political subjects.

Today, the interests of underground and aboveground Chinese artists have continued to diverge, essentially yielding two independent schools of thought. In one camp, artists like Ai Weiwei and Zhao Zhao produce works that protest and criticize the government. *Sunflower Seeds*, Ai's most famous piece, is a massive pool filled with nearly 100 million hand-carved porcelain sunflower seeds. The work comments on China's government-imposed uniformity. Other pieces make





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their points even more bluntly: one iconic 1995 black-and-white portrait of Ai shows him flipping his middle finger at Tiananmen Square. "If my art has nothing to do with people's pain and sorrow, what is 'art' for?" Ai said in a 2016 interview.

Others approach the question, "What is art for?" quite differently. Cao Fei, a young artist working in Beijing, told *The New Yorker* in 2015, "Criticizing society, that's the aesthetics of the last generation. ... When I started making art, I didn't want to do political things. I was more interested in subcultures, in pop culture." Ideological art, she said, has "all been expressed." Cao's art reflects her perspective: her installation *RMB City*, which appeared at the Museum of Modern Art's PS1 show in 2016, incorporates images from Chinese pop culture and Japanese manga.

Cao isn't an anomaly among young artists in China. In the same *New Yorker* article, artist Wang Jianwei is quoted saying, "It's not important that I'm from China. ... If art is good, it's good." When he spoke about Ai Weiwei, Wang said, "[I] don't care about him, and don't care about the media's worship of him."

In his work, Wang does not concentrate on Chinese identity, instead focusing on formal qualities such as the use of light, perspective, and form. In 2014, he produced *Time Temple*, a major installation for the Guggenheim Museum in New York. It is made of massive wood-block carvings and acrylic paintings intended to dismantle and examine the idea of the passage of time.

IT IS CERTAINLY SAFER for artists to avoid politics. On August 3, 2018, Chinese authorities razed Ai Weiwei's studio, *The Guardian* reported. By that point, Ai had been arrested numerous times and jailed without formal charges for 81 days. In 2009, he sustained a traumatic head injury after an alleged confrontation with Chinese secret police. But he remains committed to making political art. In fact, he believes there is no way to depoliticize art. "You can escape, you can pretend," he told *The New Yorker*, "but if you're talking about contemporary art, it's developed through struggles."

Located in the heart of the West Village in New York City, the Eli Klein Gallery features the work of contemporary Chinese artists, many of whom cannot publicly showcase their work in China. Eli Klein, the founder and owner of the gallery, discussed the importance of politics in Chinese art. In correspondence with *The Politic*, Klein wrote, "Chinese artists very often use their art to tell stories that can't be told safely in China verbally or in other contexts."

The gallery features Chow Chun Fai's work *Painting in Movies*. This exhibit portrays cutscenes with matching subtitles from Hong Kong's New Wave Cinema Movement. Many of the scenes reflect growing repression since











Hong Kong's transition from British to Chinese rule in 1997. In a statement to *The Politic*, Chow commented, "Artists should blend this concern [about politics] towards the society [with] their creative process. I hope I could bring those cultural viewpoints I value from the ivory tower into the daily life of the public." His portraits of Chinese citizens act as "allegories," as he describes them, for broader political anxieties.

Tellingly, at the end of his statement to *The Politic*, Chow repeated a 1943 quotation from journalist Italo Calvino: *L'apologo nasce in tempi d'oppressione. Quando l'uomo non puo' dar chiara forma al suo pensiero, lo esprime per mezzo di favole.*

"In the time of suppression, there are allegories. When a person cannot freely express his own thoughts, he would create fables."

IN A 2014 SPEECH to Beijing's leading artists, propaganda officials, and armed forces representatives, General Secretary of the Chinese Communist Party Xi Jinping discussed the role of the arts in China.

"Art and culture will emit the greatest positive energy when the Marxist view of art and culture is firmly established," Xi said, according to a *New York Times* translation of his speech. He added, "Some artists ridicule what is noble, distort the classics. ... Their work is shoddy and strained, they have created cultural garbage."

"What art criticism needs to be," Xi said, "is *just* criticism." Even so, Xi's government censored Cao Fei's piece, *RMB City*, even though its content was not overtly political. Officials objected to the mock Tiananmen Square and a statue of Chairman Mao floating in the sea in RMB City. In response, Cao created a "clean version," she told *The New Yorker*.

Chinese contemporary artists frequently return to Ai's question: "What is art for?" For some, art ought to defend art as an idea, a concept, a vehicle for expression and dissent and freedom. When Xiao Lu walked into the National Gallery of Art in 1989, she fired what many journalists have referred to as "the first shots at Tiananmen." They were shots that would echo through Chinese art and politics well into the modern day.

The Calculus of Retention

Why Are Yale Students Leaving STEM?

BY **HENRY REICHARD**

PHILSANG YOO HEARD a patter of footsteps behind him, turned away from a blackboard cluttered with mathematical formulae, and saw that three more students had entered the lecture room. His eyes widened. "I didn't expect so many," he said, chuckling uneasily. By now about thirty people had crowded inside, and several of them seemed to be compulsively counting and recounting themselves, unable to believe that so many Yale students would want to attend a public lecture on "Quantum Field Theory for Math Majors." Yoo is a professor of mathematics; in front of him there were mathematics majors, physics majors, students who had taken Directed Studies, two amateur poets, a journalist, a gray-bearded professor who intermittently pulled out an inhaler, and, sitting quietly in the back row, a junior with blue eyes and hair the color of sunburnt hay who would, in a few days, be flying back to Oxford to study mathematics far away from Yale.

Connor Halleck-Dube '19 is the sort of student that Yale has been eager to attract for decades. He's someone who knew something about general relativity before stepping foot on campus, who was comfortable with proof-based mathematics before the first lecture of Math 230. There are many reasons he decided to study abroad in his junior year, one of which was the sparsity of Yale's offerings in abstract algebra.

"Why don't we have a class in homological algebra?" he later asked me over dinner in an incredulous tone. "That's really important for anyone who studies *anything* in algebra." Oxford does have an undergraduate course in homological algebra, along with a mathematics faculty who, in Connor's opinion, commit far more attention to teaching undergraduates than the faculty of Yale.

After Yoo's lecture, with several other students gathered around, Connor put his feet up on the chair in front of him, leaned back, and began describing one of the most memorable dinnertime conversations he had overheard at Oxford. He had been sitting at a table in St. Catherine's dining hall. Nearby, a group of senior tutors had been discussing how they could shape the incoming class of math majors. There was a particularly gifted student in the new class. "How do we structure this course to challenge this student while not leaving all the others behind?" one of the tutors had asked. Connor had listened to the conversation, entranced and dumbfounded.

"I mean, can you imagine Casson and the other senior math faculty at Yale sitting down and saying, 'How do we want to shape the math majors in the Class of 2019?'" Connor asked us. There was a chorus of muffled laughter. It wasn't the sort of thing any of us had overheard or could imagine overhearing at Yale. As a senior majoring in mathematics and physics, I have never taken a course in mathematics taught by a full professor. In fact, I had never spoken with Andrew Casson, the director of undergraduate studies (DUS) in mathematics from 2012 to 2018, before interviewing him for this article.

FIVE YEARS AGO, as a junior in high school, I didn't plan on applying to Yale. I was interested in mathematics, physics, and engineering. I daydreamed about proving the Riemann Hypothesis or spearheading the nanotechnological revolution in Silicon Valley. Yale, I was sure, wouldn't be right for me. Then I began receiving personalized emails and letters and brochures: assurances that modern-day Yale *was* right—right for any STEM major, far more right than Stanford or Harvard or MIT.

In 2007, former Yale University President Richard Levin set a goal for the university: an incoming class that was 40 percent STEM. In an interview with the *Yale Daily News*, Ayaska Fernando, the former director of STEM recruitment at Yale, said that in 2009 the admissions department began sending a Yale brochure to every stu-

dent who scored a five on an AP Physics exam. In the same year, members of Yale's admissions department began traveling to parts of the country known for producing strong STEM students to host specialized "STEM forums." In 2011, Yale inaugurated Yale Engineering and Science (YES) Weekend—an admitted students event designed to convince students with strong technical skills to matriculate. In the spring of 2012, the university reached Levin's forty-percent benchmark, and today the proportion of STEM majors is close to fifty percent.

Fifty percent, that is, among the matriculating pre-frosh. Among the seniors, it's closer to thirty.

Why is the attrition rate so high in STEM? Andrew Casson told me that the mathematics department currently has a record number of majors. "We undoubtedly have more students, but we don't have more faculty," he said. "On the whole, I would say we're more understaffed than we were [a decade ago]." Roger E. Howe, a former mathematics chair, told me that the department now relies on Gibbs Professors—post-docs with a three-year teaching contract—as a direct result of the longstanding shortage of tenured professors. "We had a couple of losses and retirements, and then we were seriously undermanned," Howe said. "And I felt that the administration didn't take the situation as seriously as it should have."

Ronald Coifman, the Phillips Professor of Math and Computer Science, was more blunt. "There used to be twenty-five [mathematics professors]. It dropped down to twelve. Now it's moving back towards twenty-five. We're not moving up; we're moving back to ground level." Coifman's assessment of the situation in applied math was even harsher. "Applied math is not just understaffed—it's underwater. It doesn't really exist. The university likes to say it does."

Corey O'Hern, the DUS for mechanical engineering, told me that the number of junior and senior majors in his department has quadrupled since 2004. The number of ladder faculty (tenured or tenure-track instructors) is less than it was in 1996. As DUS, O'Hern is responsible for providing academic advice to the roughly 100 junior and senior mechanical engineering majors at Yale. He is one of only 13 ladder faculty in the Department of Mechanical Engineering and Materials Science. "We're on the low end of small," he told me. "If you increased the faculty, we'd still be small. You start losing intimacy at maybe thirty faculty."

James Slattery, the associate provost for research at Yale, declined to comment on understaffing. Slattery remarked, though, that Yale has invested in upgrading campus facilities, including a renovation of Sterling Chemistry Lab and the construction of the Center for Engineering Innovation and Design—an interdisciplinary hub for student design projects. "STEM continues to be a focus for Yale and will continue to be for the foreseeable

future," Slattery emphasized.

Several senior faculty told me that understaffing almost certainly contributes to the high attrition rate among undergraduate STEM majors. I spoke about the twin issues of attracting and retaining STEM majors with Stephanie Spear '19—a senior astrophysics major who last year served as head science tour guide for Yale Admissions. Both Spear and Colin Hill '19, last year's head engineering tour guide, told me that on tours they always emphasize the personal attention STEM students receive at Yale: the small classes, the ample opportunities for independent research, the close relationships with faculty members facilitated by the remarkable student-to-faculty ratio. "Even on our STEM tours themselves, we really try to emphasize the small-group environment," Spear told me. Engineering and science tours are designed to be significantly smaller than regular campus tours.

Spear admits, though, that she may be painting an overly rosy picture of life at Yale as a STEM major. The high proportion of the incoming class planning to major in STEM, Spear told me, is a tangible result of Levin's changes. "As far as retention goes," Spear said, "I think the bigger question is, 'Why are we not retaining these students over the course of four years?'"

"Applied math is not just understaffed—it's underwater. It doesn't really exist. The university likes to say it does."

WHEN ALEX GARTNER '19 visited Yale over YES Weekend in the spring before her first year, she quickly heard about the small classes and close relationships with professors she would enjoy as an engineering student. She spoke with chairs of departments, received a likely letter, and was told repeatedly about the celebrated one-to-one student-to-faculty ratio in engineering.

It's unclear how the admissions department concocted this statistic. When I told O'Hern about it, he was incredulous. And when Alex arrived at Yale the following fall and took Multivariable Calculus for Engineers (ENAS 151)—a 50-student introductory course required for most engineering majors—it was hard not to notice a discrepancy between the picture painted in YES Weekend and her actual experience as an electrical engineering student at Yale.

"At the beginning, you could definitely see that the professors didn't care," Alex said. "Teaching was a side job that distracted from research." The professor for her calculus course initially did not offer office hours; later, under duress, he agreed to hold them for half an hour after each class. The course was an ordeal. Online evaluations from Yale Course Search include the following: "The class was basically self-taught," "I would not take this class again even if I was paid to," "Take it with a different professor. You might want to still be an engineer if you take it with someone else," and, "Please God don't take this course."

By Alex's senior year, only one professor had spoken with her about graduate school or career opportunities. She has consistently had to find summer internships on her own. "I'm now questioning whether or not to pursue engineering after school as a career," Alex told me. "I feel severely unprepared for engineering in the real world, particularly when I hear about some of the engineering work friends at other schools have done."

There are many prospective Yale STEM majors who, after an intensely unpleasant experience in an introductory class, decide they don't like STEM as much as they thought they did. Take Charlie Romano '19, who started out as a double major in music and biomedical engineering. The biomedical engineering major has an extraordinarily extensive list of prerequisites; over his first two years, Charlie took introductory courses in chemistry, biology, and mathematics, most of which had over 100 students. Finally, after a full two years of preparatory coursework, he took his first class in biomedical engineering. "Probably the worst class I've ever taken," Charlie reflected, grimacing slightly at the memory. "[The professor] was a really brilliant guy, but he didn't care about teaching at all. The definition of dispassionate." The semester afterward, Charlie dropped the biomedical engineering major and decided to focus exclusively on music. In music, needless to say, he is not taking 100-person classes.

In moments when the university

has faced fiscal troubles, STEM departments have often been the first to face budget cuts. The origins of the understaffing issue in math, engineering, and several other STEM departments can be traced back to just such a moment twenty-seven years ago. There are many departments with stories to tell about the 1990s. Perhaps none of them, though, has a story as distinctive as that of engineering.



Students work in the Yale Center for Engineering Innovation & Design. PHOTO BY **SURBHI BHADARWAJ**

IN 1991, TWELVE MEMBERS of Yale's Faculty of Arts and Sciences were asked to perform an unpleasant task. The university was struggling: revenue sources had dwindled, departmental expenses had burgeoned, and numerous facilities (including the residential colleges) were in desperate need of costly repairs. If Yale was to survive, then costs had to be cut. The twelve faculty members appointed to the Committee on Restructuring the Faculty of Arts and Sciences began developing a plan to reduce ladder faculty positions by 15 percent.

The committee members were probably not warmly received by any of the departments they inspected, but they were especially mistrusted by the engineering department, which had always had an up-and-down relationship with the administration. Forty years ago, Yale Engineering enrolled close to a thousand majors—nearly 25 percent of all Yale undergraduates—and it was estimated that the university had produced 15 percent of all engineers in the United States. But there was something suspiciously vocational about engineering that did not sit well with the more classically minded members of the administration. According to professor emeritus of geology and geophysics Robert Gordon, who began teaching metallurgy at Yale in 1957, "Misconceptions about Engineering appear to have been deeply imbedded in the Yale administration. Rumor had it that the president and provost saw what we did in the Metallurgy Department as a form of advanced blacksmithing."

During the presidencies of Alfred Griswold and Kingman Brewster, the Yale undergraduate admissions office favored students with strong liberal arts backgrounds over those with technical skills. This preference, along with a reorganization of Yale Engineering that combined all of the previous three departments into one, had catastrophic effects. In 1966, the Engineers Council for Professional Development—a national organization that evaluates engineering programs—denied accreditation to Yale's newly reorganized engineering department. By that time, there were only 48 engineering majors and 116 science majors at Yale.

By 1991, Yale Engineering had split back into three departments, regained accreditation, and had a respectable number of majors. But the department was still a far cry from what it had once been, and it would never regain its former prominence without significant expansion. In its formal report, the Committee on Restructuring the Faculty of Arts and Sciences wrote, "The chairs also believe that engineering as a whole cannot and should not be expected to reach national prominence unless it is allowed to grow substantially."

The committee members were not willing to guillotine engineering wholesale. But they were willing to cripple it. In its final report, the committee recommended recombining all of the engineering departments and eliminating nearly 23 percent of junior faculty-equivalent positions. By comparison, English and History—both of which were independently larger than all of the engineering departments put together—would each suffer a reduction of about seven percent.

The backlash to the committee's recommendations was immediate and fervent. The Faculty of Arts and

Sciences set up an independent review committee a month after the initial report came out in January; by March, the independent committee had rejected many of the restructuring committee's resolutions. The provost resigned in March. By April 1992, the president of Yale and the dean of Yale College had followed suit.

When Richard Levin was elected to the Yale presidency in 1993, he must have been keenly aware of the circumstances that led to his predecessor's resignation. Levin had been one of the 12 faculty on the restructuring committee. In a recent interview, he reflected that the 23 percent reduction recommended by the committee was far smaller than what the administration had initially proposed.

"The administration was suggesting, for example, closing engineering. Closing sociology. It was pretty drastic," Levin told me. "There was a lot of skepticism about whether we could have a competitive engineering department at Yale."

Levin did not share that skepticism. After the university's finances improved, he began to invest heavily in STEM. He appointed D. Allan Bromley—a former U.S. presidential science advisor—as dean of the engineering school. In 2000, he announced a 500-million-dollar plan to upgrade the university's science and engineering facilities (only two new science buildings had been constructed at Yale in the past 30 years). In 2007, he announced that undergraduate admissions would seek to attract an incoming class consisting of at least 40 percent STEM majors.

But as the number of STEM majors at Yale increased, many faculty became increasingly uneasy. Who would teach all the new students? Would the administration begin hiring a significant number of new faculty in STEM departments? The answer appeared to be no. While a few departments expanded, many others did not.

"We never made a big announcement or a specific initiative around increasing the number of faculty in STEM as a whole," Levin told me. "When we started, the faculty were underutilized."

JOHN WETTLAUFER, THE DUS of applied mathematics, does not feel underutilized. "I don't have enough time to meet with students. I don't have enough time to supervise undergraduate research projects. I only have a certain bandwidth to be an advisor to students," he told me. "Our applied math students are a great source of help and energy for the program. It seems that every time we hire a faculty member, another institution is hiring three."

At Harvard, the equivalent to the DUS of applied mathematics has undergraduate assistants who help provide academic advice to students. When I asked Wettlaufer how close Yale was in STEM to more technical universities such as Harvard or MIT, he responded with repressed amusement. "We're not very close. At Harvard they're hiring left, right, and center. They have hired two full-time lecturers as associate directors of undergraduate studies in applied mathematics, who teach and advise students. At MIT, of course, there's no comparison. They have some 40 instructors or lecturers across pure and applied mathematics. In my opinion, the commitment of those institutions to STEM fields is much higher, and you can see that just from the number of faculty and lecturers that are being hired."

The small number of faculty hires has certainly contributed to poor advising. But it has also prevented Yale from increasing diversity in many STEM departments that continue to be overwhelmingly white and male. In upper-level math courses, there are rarely more than three or four female students. Hee Oh is the only female tenured professor in the mathematics department. She is the first woman to receive tenure in the department's history.

A few years ago, six undergraduates surveyed undergraduate mathematics majors about exclusion and diversity. They published the results in the Iota Report, which recommended, among other things, implementing an improved advising system and increasing diversity among faculty and graduate students. "Students look up to their professors and graduate TAs as mentors and examples," the authors noted. "It matters when they do not see anyone successful in the field who looks like them."

The surveys and testimonies in the Iota Report make another point plain. The students who turn away from mathematics, either as a result of poor classroom experiences or poor advising, are often women, members of racial minorities, or students without access to advanced mathematics courses in high school. In departments with poor advising and overworked professors, the students who change majors are frequently those who already feel out of place. Students who come in without adequate preparation, in particular, are often forced to leave STEM.

"Coming from a low-income, academically deficient background meant Yale would be hard for me, and I knew that before I showed up," one student wrote in her testimony for the Iota Report.

He didn't treat his students differently if they were women, the professor told Elisa. Why did it matter so much that there weren't more female professors in pure mathematics?

"But there was no way for me to know the extent to which my background would limit me over the next four years. A place that is defined by the opportunities it provides became the site for me to learn the areas in which I was limited. I quickly learned all STEM majors were inaccessible to me."

Faculty advisors play a crucial role in all departments at Yale, but they are especially important in STEM fields. A student who has never taken an English class can pick up the *Iliad*, flip to the twelfth book, and become entranced by Sarpedon's speech to Glaucus. But no student who hasn't studied advanced mathematics can pick up Dummit and Foote's *Abstract Algebra*, open it to chapter four, and marvel at the elegance and versatility of the Sylow Theorems for finite groups. Faculty in STEM fields who care enough (and who have enough time to care) about undergraduate education can provide a human face to subjects that, on their own, often appear sterile and inaccessible. At Yale, that human face sometimes never appears. When it does, it's almost always white and male.

"I HAVEN'T MET a single other black or Hispanic math major in my time at Yale," Elisa Martinez '18 mentioned offhandedly. Martinez, her friend Nathan Nuñez '20, and I were sitting in the Pauli Murray dining hall on a dark evening last spring. Nuñez had been telling me about Being Human in STEM—an intercollegiate program founded at Amherst that aims to bring attention to exclusivity and lack of diversity in STEM fields through student-led projects. He was part of a team that focused on surveying Yale's mathematics department.

"The math department doesn't really care about the human element of its students," Elisa continued. After years of taking math classes, this had become apparent to both of us. It cares about whether its students are able to figure out the problem sets and do well on exams.

There are some math professors who care very much about the human element. Patrick Devlin—a Gibbs Professor and the current instructor of Math 230-231, an intensive introductory sequence for students interested in pure mathematics—is one of the best-known. Devlin helps his students form study groups; he sends them encouraging emails when they feel disheartened; and, in both Math 230 and another of his courses, the first-year seminar Math as a Creative Art, he tries to convey the beauty of mathematics to his students. "I think Pat is trying to heal the perception of math as a dry and sterile subject," Lauren Chan '21, a student who took Math as a Creative Art, told me. "I think he's trying to convey that math is touchable, it's reachable—it's human."

Research in mathematics—like research in most STEM fields—is highly collaborative. Yet all too often, math majors work on problem sets, study for tests, and learn material on their own, particularly if they are somehow set apart from the other students. Almost all of the women I interviewed for this article emphasized the simultaneous importance and difficulty of finding study groups. Ami Radunskaya, the president of the national Association for Women in Mathematics and a professor at Pomona College, also emphasized that an inclusive



Leet Oliver Memorial Hall hosts part of the mathematics department. PHOTO BY **SURBHI BHADARWAJ**



culture must be a collaborative one. "In my classes," Radunskaya told me, "I insist on collaborative work. The goal should be to make collaboration the norm. One of the most important things is ensuring that people don't get isolated."

When I asked Radunskaya about the lack of diversity in Yale's mathematics department, she told me that this is a problem almost everywhere. Yale is hardly unique. But there are things that Yale and all other universities could do to improve. Several universities have experimented with a double-blind reviewing process when hiring faculty to prevent discrimination. Others have invested in cultural awareness training and in creating a collaborative culture among undergraduates. "It's really important to have open discussion about these issues," Radunskaya said. "It's a very slow boat to turn—this institution we call academia is very old-fashioned. There are so many things we cling to."

Since the Iota Report was published, the mathematics department has implemented a peer tutoring system—one of the report's recommendations. In 2017, an undergraduate organization named Dimensions was founded to support women in mathematics at Yale. And this year, the mathematics advising system expanded: there are now two DUS's, and mathematics majors are also paired with an additional faculty advisor. But the department is still one of the least diverse at Yale. Hee Oh is still the only female tenured professor in the department's history.

Elisa knows some mathematics professors, such as Devlin, who are making an active effort to increase the department's diversity. But she knows many others who seem to think that diversity isn't a significant issue. Last fall, shortly after a *Yale Daily News* article on the gender disparity in the mathematics department came out, Elisa was asked to stay after class in a mathematics seminar taught by a senior faculty member. She was the only woman in the seminar, and the professor wanted to ask her why the *News* was making diversity such a big issue. He didn't treat his students differently if they were women, the professor told Elisa. Why did it matter so much that there weren't more female professors in pure mathematics? Elisa, confused and dispirited, had not known what to say.

THERE ARE SOME STEM departments at Yale that have improved markedly in the past decade. In 2007, Yale announced that it would use gifts from two donors to create seven new faculty positions in computer science—the largest expansion of the department in more than 30 years. The Department of Computer Science has invested significant resources in providing peer tutors and teaching assistants for most of its courses, which are often large but are well-regarded. All of the students I interviewed who had taken courses in computer science praised it. "I don't think that the math department is as invested in its students as the CS department is," Yuxuan Ke '19, a double major in mathematics and computer science, told me. Carter Page '19, an economics major who abandoned pure mathematics after a disheartening introductory course, told me that he has never had a bad experience in computer science. "I have yet to take a CS class that has not been incredible," he said.

When I asked O'Hern, the DUS for mechanical engineering, about the inconsistent quality of introductory mathematics courses, he mentioned the calculus course Alex took in her first year. Previous instructors for the class once tried to split it into two sections, but the administration blocked the division, in part because it would have lessened the teaching load of the two instructors. When I asked Roger Howe a similar question, he mentioned that the mathematics department does not spend significant time teaching incoming Gibbs Professors how to be engaging instructors. "They don't get any training here," he told me. "They're just sort of supposed to be able to go into the classroom. We don't do anything to get them up to speed." And when I asked Levin why his administration set a goal for 40 percent of the incoming class to be prospective STEM majors, he spoke about the attrition rate offhandedly. "We knew the erosion was nearly 50 percent," Levin said. "If 40 percent said they wanted to do science, then about 20 percent actually ended up doing science."

Yale has reached and surpassed Levin's 40-percent benchmark, but it has done so without expanding many of its departments. When I talked with O'Hern and Coifman about the severe understaffing in departments that have not been expanded in decades, I was reminded of the question that head science tour guide Stephanie Spear had put to me in my interview with her: "Why are we not retaining these students over the course of four years?"

And when I heard Levin discuss the attrition rate as if it were an unfortunate inevitability rather than a fixable problem, I was reminded of my earlier conversation with Elisa, when she described her fruitless conversations with faculty who didn't seem to care that women and racial minorities are being driven away from mathematics.

"You get the feeling that no one higher up really cares about this issue or really wants this fixed," Elisa said, frustration evident in her tone and expression. "And I think that's true. No conversation I have ever had with anyone higher up in the math department has convinced me otherwise."

Consider the Lobstermen

Climate Change Threatens Connecticut Lobsters

BY **NISHANTH KRISHNAN**

SMALL TOWNS CLUSTER along the northern edge of Long Island Sound. Coastal marshes and inlets lie beside brightly painted homes, lighthouses, and piers. On a Sunday afternoon in Guilford, Connecticut, steeples and boat masts jut out near the water's edge; faint bells ring and birds caw in the distance. But the quiet here belies the seismic changes happening just a few miles from the shore.

For Connecticut's lobstermen, Long Island Sound has transformed into an aquatic desert over the past 20 years. The estuary's lobster population has hit historically low levels and continues to decline precipitously. In the 1990s, fishermen hauled hundreds of pounds of lobster to Guilford and other Connecticut towns every day. Long Island Sound fisheries brought in 3.7 million pounds of lobster in 1998; in 2015, they yielded just 200,000.

A subtle force drives this dramatic change. Average water temperatures in Long Island Sound have ticked up over the last four decades. In 1975, the average winter temperature recorded at a station off the New London coast was 36.5 degrees Fahrenheit. In the anomalously warm winter of 2012, the same station observed a record high average temperature of 45 degrees Fahrenheit.

The temperature change adds yet another environmental strain to a long list of existing pressures. Habitat destruction and aquatic hypoxia—unsustainably low oxygen levels caused by pollution-driven algal blooms—have jeopardized the Sound's ecosystems for decades. Despite strides in the 21st century to curtail pollution runoff into Long Island Sound, climate change has squeezed lobster populations out of the Sound toward colder waters up north. As New York and Connecticut lobstermen have caught little in recent years, their counterparts in Maine brought home over 120 million pounds of catch in 2012.

"It's been getting harder, you know. The lobsters just aren't here anymore," said Aldo Candido, a wholesaler who has worked at Lobster Bin, a Greenwich marketplace, for ten years. "For a while now, we're getting most of our lobster from Nova Scotia, from Canada," he told *The Politic*.

Around the Connecticut coast, fisheries large and small have cut back on costs—many by laying off workers—as their income diminishes. "You have an expectation that you'll have X amount of earnings, and when that doesn't occur, through no control of your own, it can be pretty devastating," said another fisherman, who works for a lobster tourism company in Massachusetts, in an interview with *The Politic*. "You learn to plan and be more conservative with your spending."

Lobsters are not the only species affected by rising temperatures. A 2015 report published in *Science* details how Atlantic cod struggled to adapt to warmer New England waters. For over half a millennium, cod fishing thrived in New England. But in the early 1970s, overfishing led to a population collapse. Climate change, in addition to the overfishing, meant that the population never rebounded to its former magnitude.

As lobster, cod, and other species move northward, southern species native to the mid-Atlantic are taking their place in Long Island Sound. The ongoing Long Island Sound Study revealed that warm-water species outnumbered cold-water species for the first time in 2002 and outnumbered them two-to-one in 2017. North Atlantic black sea bass are reportedly encroaching on parts of the Sound that were previously too cold to harbor them. The consequences of the population changes are difficult to predict. Black sea bass, for example, prey on lobster, but scientists don't yet know what this means for the ecosystem in the long term, according to the *Connecticut Mirror*.

Locals and environmental advocates have called for stringent measures to prevent overfishing of the dwindling lobster population. Over the past decade, Connecticut has adopted new restrictions, including a 2015 ban on selling female lobsters carrying eggs. Additionally, a 2006 regulation states that a lobster's carapace, the part of the shell which reflects the lobster's age, must be larger than 3.3 inches in order to harvest and sell the lobster. These regulations aim to preserve young lobsters and reproducing females in the hope that the adult lobster population will stabilize in subsequent generations.

"It's getting harder, you know. The lobsters just aren't here anymore."

"It takes lobsters anywhere from five to nine years to grow into the fisheries," said Richard Wahle, a professor at the University of Maine and director of the university's Lobster Institute. Wahle has been studying lobsters for over thirty years. In an interview with *The Politic*, he recounted how his team developed what is now known as the American Lobster Settlement Index (ALSI) in the 1990s.

ALSI leverages data on lobster eggs and larvae to make accurate predictions on future lobster populations from southern New England to Canada. Lobsters require years to develop, so alarming decreases in larval populations allow ALSI to warn the industry long before a decline in adult lobsters occurs.

"We've developed a multi-dimensional tool to see how southern New England and the Gulf of Maine might respond to future climate changes," Wahle said. "Changes in the food web, shell disease, and several ecological factors are included." Annual reports released by the ALSI provide a detailed view of lobster populations in different regions, depths, and water temperatures.

By publishing data, holding workshops, and hosting conferences, the University of Maine Lobster Institute informs government regulators on lobster fishing and advises fisheries on sustainable harvesting. "[We] bring the fishing industry and other stakeholders like fishery managers together with the talent at the University of Maine to address industry and fishery priorities," Wahle said. Data allow researchers, policymakers, and fisheries to decide on targets and caps before it is too late.

Marcos Voyatzis, a lobsterman from California, says regulations on the lobster industry can prove immensely beneficial. "A couple of years ago [the state government] put a trap limit, which helped a lot," he told *The Politic*, referring to a recent cap on the number of lobster traps a fishery can place in the Pacific Ocean off Southern California. Despite the fact that Southern California's lobster population is relatively stable and healthy, overfishing threatened to disrupt the equilibrium.

"Before, there was no trap limit, so anybody could put out whatever they want[ed]—eight, nine hundred traps," Voyatzis explained. "Now it's 300 traps, so it's a lot less gear in the water, you know?" Voyatzis believes that lobster density will increase due to this regulation. "Eventually you're going to fish with less gear but catch more lobster."

But in Connecticut, many lobstermen oppose regulations. There is little lobster to begin with, and lobstermen often find that regulations make it harder for their fisheries to stay competitive in international markets. Further complicating the problem are Chinese tariffs, which curb Connecticut fishery exports to their largest market.

Richard Burroughs, an adjunct professor of coastal science and policy at the Yale School of Forestry and Environmental Science, told *The Politic* that by regulating lobster traps, the Connecticut government is missing the big picture: rising water temperatures. Burroughs and others in academia have pushed governments and fisheries to change the way they examine threats to marine populations. They argue for a perspective that considers the full spectrum of factors that affect the health of populations.

"In the case of climate change, you are now left with a biological system that ostensibly fails because of [a] physical change that the government does not have any authority to deal with," Burroughs said.

The government can institute any number of biological and physical controls, such as banning certain pesticides to improve marine ecosystem health. Yet no matter how many are passed, Burroughs explained, regulations are unlikely to mitigate the effects of climate change in the coming decade.

A complete moratorium on lobster fishing seems increasingly likely, and statewide closures could devastate Connecticut's maritime economy. The state's lobster fisheries are a 100-million-dollar industry, even though an exodus of employees from fisheries is already underway.

Shutdowns would have striking cultural impacts. In the last century, lobsters have become embedded in the cultural fabric, local cuisine, and tourism of Connecticut. Rotary clubs draw hundreds with annual lobster festivals, including one in Chester that has run for nearly 50 years. In 1939, Harry Perry, who ran a Milford restaurant, developed a special dish to please a frequent customer—the iconic lobster roll, now served in restaurants across the U.S. and Canada.

Next year marks the twentieth anniversary of the start of the Long Island Sound lobster decline.

As the number of active lobstermen in Connecticut falls below 100, an ominous question hangs over them: how long until their livelihoods disappear with the lobsters?

The unusually warm summer of 1999 prompted lobsters to migrate to colder pockets deep in the Sound. In September of that year, Hurricane Floyd whirled up the eastern seaboard, causing extensive damage from Florida to Connecticut. The storm had dissipated by the time it reached southern New England, but torrential downpours and gusts persisted. As Floyd churned Long Island Sound, warm surface water mingled with the deep water where the lobsters resided. Severely stressed, the lobsters experienced high levels of shell disease and suffered a massive die-off.

Lobsters in the Sound had bounced back from devastating years before, but the 1999 decline never reversed.

The first half of the 1990s saw lobster fishing in the Sound at its peak, similar to Maine's industry today. Even as millions more pounds of lobsters are harvested annually, lobster fishermen in Maine are approaching the boom with caution. Taking a lesson from the crash in Connecticut, northern lobster fisheries are coordinating closely with researchers to manage lobster harvests.

Avoiding the temptation to harvest as much as possible could be key to allowing Maine's billion-dollar lobster industry to reap benefits long into the future. But researchers in the state are unsure if, or when, Maine's lobster boom will end. Senator Angus King (I-ME) has expressed concern that this uncertainty may result in job losses if lobster migrations catch the industry off-guard.

Down south, though, a painful reckoning is imminent. As the number of active lobstermen in Connecticut falls below 100, an ominous question hangs over them: how long until their livelihoods disappear with the lobsters?

Wahle is not optimistic. "The temperatures are excessive during the summers, and if projections for warming hold true, the waters will be increasingly worse for lobsters as decades pass," he said. He speculates that lobsters may not survive in Long Island Sound past 2050.

Burroughs is more hopeful. When asked if he believed there will be any lobsters in 2050, his response was quick: "I bet there will be." But he immediately responded with his own question. "Will there be a commercial fishery?"

"Well," he said resignedly, "you can probably go around and tell."

Whose Community?

Yale's Ties to New Haven's Top Public School

BY **COURTNEY NUNLEY**

ON MAY 4, 2009, Hong Zheng, a research assistant at Yale University, tried to enroll her daughter in kindergarten and discovered that the district boundary of Worthington Hooker School, a public school in New Haven's East Rock neighborhood, divided her apartment building into two parts: in-district and out-district.

Zheng happened to live in the out-district half. Her apartment building, where she had lived for seven years, was only four blocks away from Hooker's K-2 building, and two of her neighbors had sent their children to Hooker. When her daughter was denied a spot at the school, Zheng was, understandably, confused.

When Zheng applied, kindergarten spots at Hooker filled up first with in-district students—students who lived within the school's designated boundaries. Those students were prioritized for spots in the kindergarten class, and there were rarely, if ever, any spots left for out-district students. As a result, children who lived in the same building as Zheng could attend a school that Zheng's daughter couldn't. In 2009, Hooker did not keep a waiting list—so, if Zheng wanted to get her daughter into the school, her only option was to visit the registration office every day with proof of residence and her daughter's passport, on the off-chance a spot had opened up.

Zheng's story is one of many about the mysterious boundaries and pathways that allow some children—and not others—into Hooker.

"WORTHINGTON HOOKER SCHOOL, as New Haven's most culturally diverse school, prides itself on its multicultural and international student population," reads the opening line of Hooker's mission statement, from the first page of the school's 2018-2019 Parent/Student Handbook.

Though Hooker claims to be diverse, its admissions history and strong ties to Yale suggest otherwise. Hooker's student body more closely reflects the demographics of the university than the demographics of the city.

In its mission statement, in newspapers, and in online school profiles, Hooker is widely celebrated for its large percentage of international students and students who speak English as a second language. But the statistics and praise mask the fact that Hooker is considerably less racially and economically diverse than New Haven as a whole.

According to the Connecticut State Department of Education, Hooker's student population for the 2017-2018 school year was 12.7 percent black, 8.9 percent Hispanic or Latino, 45.4 percent white, 29.8 percent Asian, and 12.2 percent Free and Reduced Lunch (FRL) Eligible. That same year, the public school student population in the New Haven school district was 38.1 percent black, 45.0 percent Hispanic or Latino, 13.3 percent white, 2.1 percent Asian, and 55.4 percent FRL Eligible. That's close to four times the fraction of black and Hispanic or Latino students and FRL Eligible students in the Hooker student body.

Hooker flaunts its proximity to Yale University in its handbook. One-third of the section titled "Our Community" is dedicated to Yale. The handbook boasts, "Yale student [*sic*] serve as tutors and mentors to our students. Many of our Yale-affiliated parents share their unique talents with our students."

Annie Harper, a Hooker parent, former Yale graduate student, and current Yale faculty member, frustratedly told me that Hooker is "really a Yale school with New Haven kids awkwardly thrown into the mix."

Hooker, with its strong ties to Yale and disproportionately high concentration of white

and affluent students, is a hub of racial and economic stratification-that does not reflect New Haven.

According to the city's own policies on school choice, that should not be the case. Former ten-term New Haven Mayor John De Stefano, Jr. told me that the school-choice model was introduced to New Haven in part to promote more widespread academic achievement through school desegregation. Advocates of school choice purport that by admitting part of their classes by lottery, neighborhood schools like Hooker can better reflect the demographic profile of the city.

Part of the mission stated on the New Haven Public Schools of Choice website is "foster[ing] student enrollment patterns that reflect racial, ethnic and economic diversity." Yet Hooker remains one of the most privileged public schools in New Haven. So why are there still such enormous differences between its student body and New Haven's student population? Who is allowed to go to Hooker, and why is Yale's influence on the school so powerful?

HOOKER'S TIES TO YALE started with its founding in 1900. The school is named after former Yale University professor, physician, and New Haven school board member Worthington Hooker. Since the 1980s, Yale professors and graduate students have openly discussed their stakes in Hooker.

In 1981, Hooker and other elementary schools in New Haven faced threats of closure due to budget cuts. More than 100 Yale graduate students whose children attended Hooker asked then-Yale President A. Bartlett Giamatti, among others, to use his influence to keep Hooker open. Giamatti ultimately decided not to interfere, but the school stayed open anyway thanks to a budget expansion. When asked why he didn't interfere, Giamatti told the *Yale Daily News* in 1981 that Yale did not have an obligation to an individual public school, like Hooker, that would merit an intervention.

The *News* article does not mention any acknowledgement by Giamatti that Hooker educated the children of over 100 Yale graduate students.

Nearly a decade later, in the early 1990s, Hooker still had clear ties to Yale. One *News* article from 1992 praised the "unusually high number of international students at Hooker"—most of whom, the same article noted, were children of Yale graduate students or professors. Ironically, the article was published in the *News*' "Communiversity" issue, dedicated to discussing cross-cultural understanding between the New Haven community and Yale.

The high representation of wealthy students at Hooker reflects Yale's faculty and graduate and professional student populations. In the 1990s, the average salary of a Yale professor was 82,266 dollars, while the average salary of a New Haven resident was 35,058 dollars, according to the Yale University Office of Institutional Research and the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. Although Yale has not published demographic statistics on graduate students enrolled in the 1990s, the statistics Yale published for the 2016-17 academic year are revealing. That year, international students made up 36 percent and 21 percent of Yale's graduate and professional school programs, respectively. And in 1994, the *News* reported that the majority of the 42 percent of faculty living off campus lived on Whitney Avenue in the East Rock Neighborhood—right by the Hooker School.

IN THE EARLY 2000s, questions about districting and demographics at Hooker sparked controversy. The New Haven school district has been a system of choice for decades, fashioned to foster widespread academic achievement and school desegregation. The school choice placement process involves an application and a lottery for all students applying to magnet, charter, or kindergarten neighborhood schools. The New Haven Magnet Schools website clearly lays out the steps of the school choice placement process, the order in which preference is given to students on waitlists, and the names of schools to choose from. However, until 2011, the placement process for Hooker remained unclear to its applicants.

In 2004, parents began asking questions about preferential admissions at Hooker when out-district students who were children of powerful figures—State Representative Cam Staples' daughter and former school board President Brian Perkins' daughter—were granted early confirmed spots in the over-enrolled kindergarten class. Each year, the largest number of Hooker's applicants are let into the kindergarten class, with few spots left for older students to transfer into the school later. The controversies surrounding Hooker's exclusive and unclear admissions process, particularly for the kindergarten class, grew more heated in 2008 and 2009, as stories like Hong Zheng's were publicized by

Hooker, with its strong ties to Yale and disproprtionately high concentration of white and affluent students, is a hub of racial and economic stratification that does not reflect New Haven.

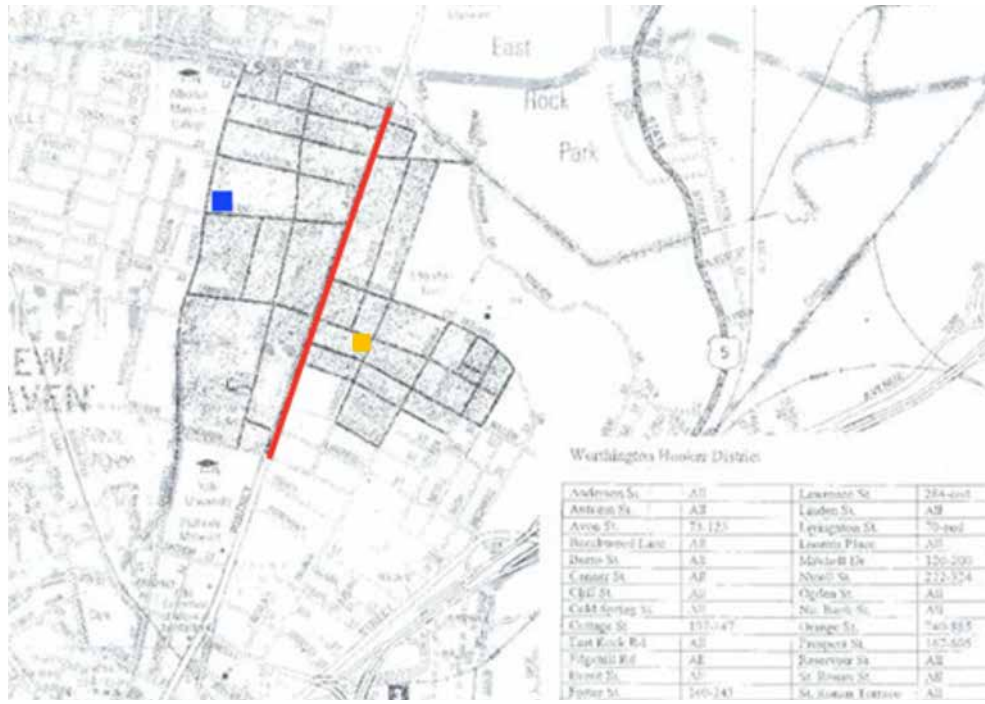
the *New Haven Independent*.

Amid controversy, multiple administrators at Hooker and officials in the New Haven Board of Education offered unclear answers to the speculation that they gave certain students preferential treatment. Debbie Sumpter-Breland, the student recruitment coordinator at the New Haven Board of Education, told the *Independent* in June 2009 that kindergarten spots at Hooker were filled first with in-district students; the only way to get a spot, she said, was to come down to the registration office every day and hope one opened up.

Will Clark, Hooker's chief operating officer at the tie, is quoted in the same *Independent* article saying that whenever a spot became available at Hooker, former longstanding New Haven schools Superintendent Reggie Mayo would look at the list of registered students and personally choose who would be given the seat, instead of moving down a set waitlist. Clark added that, for Hooker, Mayo would give preference to siblings, those with transportation needs, those enrolled in pre-kindergarten programs funded by Head Start, and English as a second language students.

Later in June 2009, Sumpter-Breland held a school board meeting that turned contentious. Her response to questions about Hookers' admissions process inflamed parents' outrage. At one point, she reportedly threw up her hands and exclaimed, "That's how it works!"

While parents kept pressuring the school district and Board of Alders for answers, the *Independent* obtained and published the coveted map of Hooker's district in July 2009. The map had never before been available to the public. After years of uncertainty about how to get into Hooker, the map was expected to give parents and families answers.



A copy of the original district map obtained and published by the *Independent*. The map has been marked with colored symbols to correspond with information included in this article.

THE RELEASE OF HOOKER'S district map did not calm concerned parents. If anything, it intensified their frustration.

Hooker's K-2 building, marked in yellow on the map, is on the corner of Canner Street and Livingston Street—blocks away from the district's boundaries. On the map, Hooker's district contains the areas of New Haven largely populated by Yale affiliates: Whitney Avenue, marked in red on the map, home to many off-campus Yale faculty members, and multiple Yale graduate student housing buildings, including one that's marked in blue on the map, Whitehall, that Yale recommends to graduate students as "located within a highly respected school district" on a university web page about graduate housing. The map also shows that a surprisingly small portion of the East Rock neighborhood is considered in-district for Hooker, even though it is supposedly an East Rock neighborhood school. Additionally, the map includes Zheng's address as in-district, only adding to the confusion over the school's district boundaries.

After the map was published, stories spread of families paying off graduate students in the Hooker district to use their addresses, or renting a home in the district for the purpose of enrolling a child at Hooker and living elsewhere.

Annie Harper recalled that in 2009, she and her husband were Yale graduate students sending one of their sons to the Head Start pre-kindergarten program while living in the Hooker district. She said her son was the only student that she knew of in the program who lived in Hooker's district.

Harper remembers the moment the map appeared on the *Independent*'s website. She described it as "worth its weight in gold." Once they realized that Harper lived within Hooker's district lines, multiple families in the Head Start program asked her, "Do you have an extra room at your house? Can I list that as my address?"

Parents complained that the requirement to apply for a spot in person at the registration office during normal business hours placed an undue burden on working parents and gave an advantage to well-connected parents who were tipped off through their social networks whenever a spot opened up. And parents couldn't understand how a system like Mayo's, where he personally chose which students to admit, could possibly be unbiased.

Finally, in 2011, the New Haven Board of Education responded to parent concerns and implemented a more transparent waiting list lottery system in all New Haven neighborhood school

kindergartens. The lottery affects schools that serve distinct districts, like Hooker. Open spots in kindergartens go to the first people who show up on registration day, while spots on the waiting list are assigned by lottery.

THE NEW LOTTERY SYSTEM may answer the question so many parents had with Hooker: *How on earth do you get in?* However, Hooker's issues don't end there. Despite a better and more transparent admissions process, the school still has major problems when it comes to race and class. Yet parents vie to win their children admission. So, why Hooker?

Hooker is not the problem. Rather, it is a small example of a larger problem that has plagued the city for three centuries: Yale, with its power and prestige, gets to dictate the narrative of New Haven on a platform that the city's own residents don't have access to.

When I spoke with John DeStefano about New Haven's schools maintaining small class sizes despite the high demand for spots in kindergartens and elementary schools in the city, he told me, "Increasing the number of seats goes against the goal of creating smaller communities."

Smaller communities are great in a number of ways: less anonymity in schools, closer student-teacher relationships. But when you look at Hooker, you have to question what smaller community the school is trying to create. A community of wealth? A community of privilege? A microcosm of the Yale community?

Before Annie Harper and her husband came to Yale and their children went to Hooker, they lived in Zimbabwe together. When they heard the news that they both were accepted to Yale for graduate school, they were, as she put it, "over the moon." But soon after their acceptances, several people warned them about the "dangers" and "pitfalls" of living in New Haven. Even on another continent, Harper already had the perception of Yale being "some great university in a bad city." With the heavy police presence on campus, the gradual acquisition of originally Quinnipiac land, and minimal university-wide education on how to engage with the city, Yale does little to change the stigmatizing narratives about New Haven.

Yale does little to change the stigmatizing narratives about New Haven. The Yale bubble exists.

The Yale bubble exists. You can see it on Cross Campus, in the Shops on Broadway, and up Science Hill. And you can see it at Hooker. Harper said it best when she told me, "Yale does a great job of keeping you here for four years without you feeling like you're in New Haven." The Yale stamp of approval, whether by word of mouth or through blue signs on buildings, has separated the good from the bad in New Haven on the university's own, unchecked scale. Hooker falls in with the good partially because it's one of the whitest and wealthiest schools in the city, but also because it has that coveted Yale stamp of approval.

TO LEARN ABOUT VIABLE educational options in East Rock beyond Hooker, I talked to Anika Singh Lemar, a clinical associate professor at Yale Law School who lives in East Rock. She and her husband, a local politician, sent their children to East Rock Community Magnet School, even though they were in-district for Hooker.

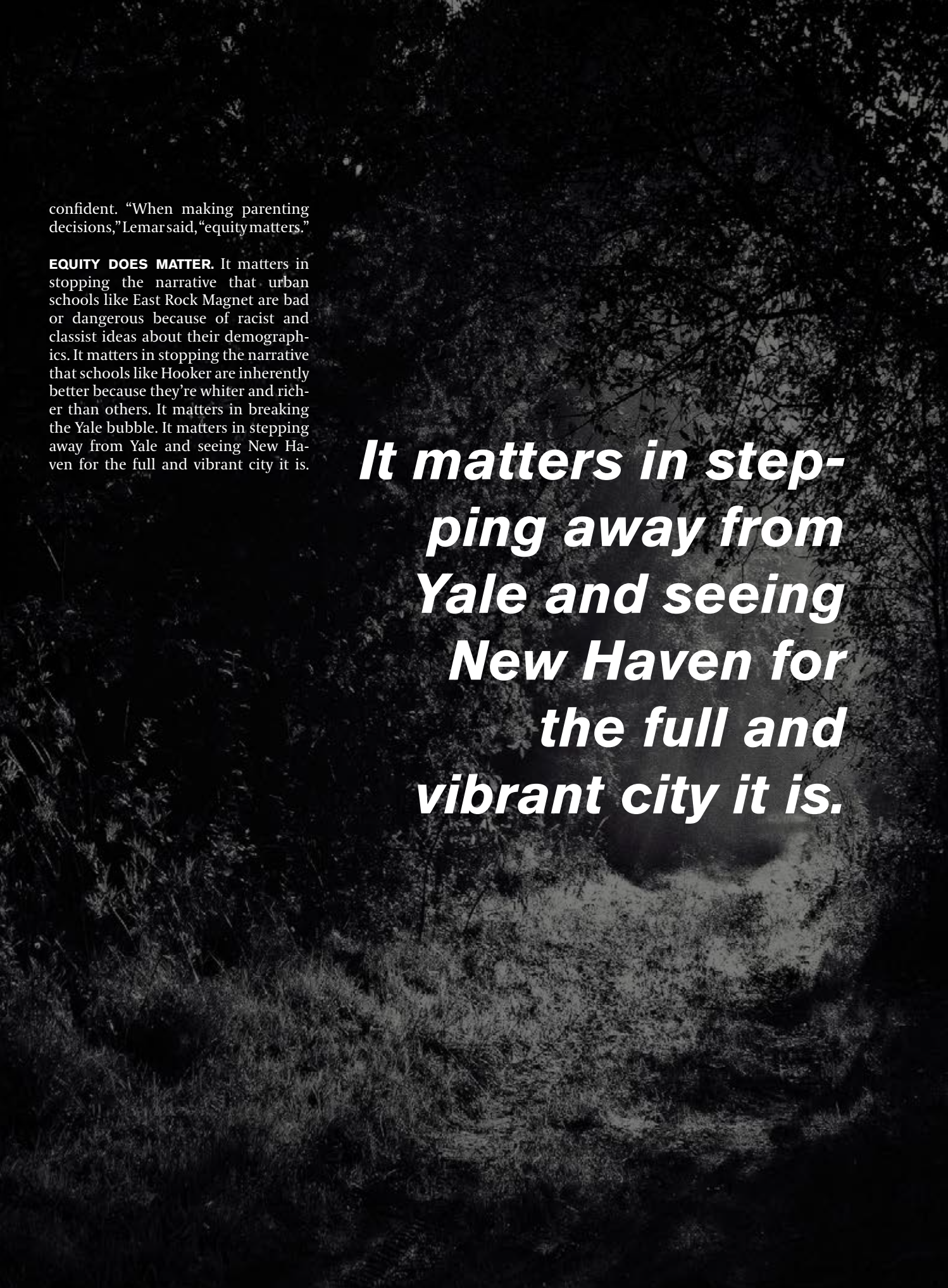
Lemar quickly realized there was a common assumption among parents in the East Rock community: if you live in-district for Hooker, you send your kids there without even considering other options. Choosing another East Rock school over Hooker? "Nobody did that."

When Lemar talked to Hooker parents, they would ask her, "Don't you miss having art classes?" Shocked, she would respond that her children could take art, gym, and music classes at East Rock Magnet. Today, she and her husband are two of many New Haveners urging an end to what they've found to be a baseless but widespread "Hooker or bust" mentality.

Lemar and her husband initially worried about the choice they made for their kids. Then they read Nikole Hannah-Jones' article in *The New York Times*, "Choosing a School for My Daughter in a Segregated City," in which Hannah-Jones discusses why she and her husband—a black, middle-class couple—deliberately enrolled their daughter Najya in a low-income, predominantly black and Hispanic New York City public school. Najya could have gone to a "carefully curated" integrated school with just enough brown and black students to "create diversity," but not too many. But her parents did not see that kind of integration as true integration that could solve educational inequality. They decided to live their convictions.

confident. "When making parenting decisions," Lemar said, "equity matters."

EQUITY DOES MATTER. It matters in stopping the narrative that urban schools like East Rock Magnet are bad or dangerous because of racist and classist ideas about their demographics. It matters in stopping the narrative that schools like Hooker are inherently better because they're whiter and richer than others. It matters in breaking the Yale bubble. It matters in stepping away from Yale and seeing New Haven for the full and vibrant city it is.



It matters in stepping away from Yale and seeing New Haven for the full and vibrant city it is.

Tugged Out of Narcissism

An Interview with **Frank Bruni**, Columnist for *The New York Times*

BY **ERIC WALLACH**

FRANK BRUNI HAS BEEN with *The New York Times* since 1995, serving as a metropolitan reporter, writer for Sunday Arts & Leisure, White House correspondent, Rome bureau chief, and chief restaurant critic. In 2011, he became the *Times*'s first openly gay columnist in the newspaper's 160-year history, writing twice weekly and covering topics including American politics, higher education, pop culture, and gay rights. Bruni is also the author of three *New York Times* best sellers: *Where You Go Is Not Who You'll Be*, *Born Round*, and *Ambling into History*.

***The Politic*: In *Where You Go Is Not Who You'll Be*, you write about your decision to forego studying at Yale in favor of UNC-Chapel Hill. Referring to your parents, you write: "They told me, repeatedly, to forget about the money. They insisted on it. But a part of me refused to. I didn't want to be a person who could forget that so easily." How were your views influenced by your upbringing, and specifically, this college decision?**

Frank Bruni: I made a decision about where to go to college that was divorced from the simple question of *prestige*. I don't know whether that was the right or wrong decision—you can't be the best judge of your own life—but what it did show me, since my world didn't collapse, since I had a wonderful college experience and education, since I went on to many jobs and adventures that I was very grateful to have…is that there are a variety of ways to make the decision about where to go to college. And there is definitely a certain subset of American teenagers who…believe that you go to the school…that has the most prestige as conventionally measured. I guess the fact that I didn't do that and

have never been dissatisfied with the results simply taught me...that there are more flexible and broader ways of thinking about the question of where to go to college.

Ruth Whippman of *The New York Times* just wrote a piece called, "Everything Is for Sale Now. Even Us," which you retweeted. She says, "In this cutthroat human marketplace, we are worth only as much as the sum of our metrics." Do you see parallels between the mania of the college process, the metrics of *U.S. News & World Report*, and other facets of society?

That's tough. It's funny because when people are on social media, they're often not visibly in the company of other people. ... People, in a weird way, are more conscious of the audiences in their lives than they were before, and because of that, I think they can be more vulnerable to and sensitive to superficial judgements in a way that I don't think is psychologically healthy. So, I think maybe that thread runs through the mania people feel to get into a college that is going to flatter them, that when they wear that t-shirt or sweatshirt, or when they mention that name, they will feel proud and validated. That may kind of reflect a consciousness of the audiences in one's life that is also a phenomenon that exists and is exacerbated by social media.

Do you see positives to social media as well?

There is this other side to social media that I do think we're not talking about that pushes back against and argues for not just its utility, but even its beauty. I wrote the piece that you referenced..."The Internet Will Be the Death of Us."...and a few people responded, saying: "You know what? When I had X disease, social media was salvation." "When I was suffering X problem, finding a community of people, and finding advice, and finding listening boards on social media meant everything." "Social media was my route to really important information about treatment, or about counseling." A lot of people wrote me that, and it's an important thing for all of us to remember. Social media, when it's functioning in its most idealized and utopian way, is this powerful and, in some situations, life-saving connector.

One quote that stands out in your book is that "Schools are businesses as well as laboratories of learning—and maybe businesses *before* laboratories of learning." Can you dive into that a bit?

When you look at schools that pour a lot of money into certain amenities, the clichéd, stereotypical example is the climbing wall, but a lot of schools have them. I've written about this, and I've used some of the more floored examples like the lazy rivers—

"People, in a weird way, are more conscious of the audiences in their lives than they were before, and because of that, I think they can be more vulnerable to and sensitive to superficial judgements..."

"I am extremely focused these days, in my own thoughts, on the importance of empathy and perspective."

MSU has a lazy river. When you see schools pouring money into the gleam of dormitories, or the sexiness of recreational opportunities, or the splendiferousness of dining options…none of that has to do with education. That is about luring more students…getting so many applications that you can then reject a certain number, end up with a very low acceptance rate, and thus enjoy the prestige that people associate with low acceptance rates. … There's no way you can deem that impulse, or that exercise, educational.

The question as to whether Yale is a "business" came up in 2015 with the Christakis incident. Many students argued that residential college deans have an obligation to create a "home" for undergraduates. I think the pervasive thought on our campus is that Yale does so incredibly much for us that it really is a home away from home. Do you think it's dangerous for us students to think that way or to forget that Yale is also a for-profit business?

College is de facto a home to students for nine months of four, five, or six years. The configuration can also be different from that. People go to school in many different ways. And, I should add, college is not a home for many people: maybe the majority of them in the country, I haven't looked at the figures lately, go to college in a commuter fashion, in a part-time fashion—I'm pretty sure that is the majority. For those people who are having a residential college experience, and who are living the majority of a year for four, five, or six years at a college, you can't avoid or edit out the fact that the college is their home. I think what can be problematic is if you expect a college to be a place *purely* of nurture, because the truth of the matter is that even a family, and a home, isn't always that.

Moving away from the word "home," one of the things that I think concerned some people watching that unfold at Yale was that some of us heard or worried that we heard, in those complaints around that time or in the voice of that student who was shouting at [Professor Christakis], the notion that college owed you complete comfort and absolute emotional and intellectual safety. College owes you *physical safety*, but I would direct you to what I think is one of the most eloquent takes on this, on this whole notion on what degree and what kind of safety you're owed by colleges—and that's really what that shouting and argument was about. … It's a quote [by Van Jones] that I've used in a lot of public speeches. It's a long quote where he says, "I don't want you to be safe, ideologically; I don't want you to be safe, emotionally; I want you to be *strong*. That's different." And that, I think, is one of the questions or takeaways from that whole incident. Were students, at Yale, expecting to always be made to feel emotionally and intellectually safe? And if so, is that consistent with the best kind of education, which can be challenging and which can be provocative?

Are there any questions that you wish interviewers would ask you? Any last thoughts you'd like Yale students to consider?

And here I will participate in the narcissism of our era. I am extremely focused these days, in my own thoughts, on the importance of empathy and perspective. I wish we would do a better job instilling in young people a sense of perspective, and I wish there were a way to imbue young people, and I would say, I wish you would all kind of find a sense of perspective. Not because you don't have it—[not] at all. This isn't a comment that's prompted by any failing I see. But I think in a world in which social media gives us these erroneous and sometimes funny glimpses of other people's lives, I think that it's way too easy to fall prey to pity and envy and not to understand that all these kinds of better things you think you see out there, all these people who you think have an easier stride or a much better time… if you had a true and complete look at their lives, if you were looking in a total 360-degree way at everything around you, I think you would find it harder, when you have that sort of perspective, to become self-consumed in either negative or positive ways. And when I say "you," I mean "we," all of us. And so, I just wish we would all spend more time thinking about and practicing the talent of perspective. I think it would tug us out of our narcissism, and in many cases, I think it would tug us out of traps of envy and self-pity.

on-line pre-view

Want to get involved with *The Politic*?
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thepolitic@yale.edu

Time Off, Not Timeout: Yale's Withdrawal and Leave of Absence Policies

Students seeking to take extended time off from Yale have two options: a leave of absence or withdrawal from Yale. Each option comes with its own sacrifices and requirements—like taking two classes during time off or alerting the administration months in advance. Nick Randos '22 discusses how Yale's leave policies impact undergraduate students.

Tampering with Nature: Isle Royale's Dwindling Wolf Population

Isle Royale is a wildlife biologist's dream. A remote, federally-protected island located in Lake Superior, it is almost completely undisturbed by humans. Yet, due to a lack of genetic diversity, Isle Royale's wolves faced the threat of extinction. Kevin Swain '20 investigates human efforts to resurrect the wolf population.

Maori Revival: New Zealand's Efforts to Retain Its Indigenous Language

On paper, the Maori people's rights have been recognized since New Zealand's colonization, but discrimination against the Maori has remained widespread over the years. Now, a new generation is fighting to preserve New Zealand's indigenous culture. Hadley Copeland '22 explores how their efforts have revived the Maori language.

The Old Faces of Davenport: A History in Portraits

If you were to walk into Davenport College's dining hall and gaze at the portraits on the walls, you would find two paintings that look unlike the rest. New to Davenport's collection, the portraits depart from the tradition of robed men glowering down at students eating dinner and instead portray a warm, lively scene: Davenport brunch. Canning Malkin '21 reflects on the portraits and their importance.

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